KITCHEN & KETTLE

Seasonal Preservation Calendar

Works because it works.

A month-by-month guide to what's in season, what to preserve, and how — for a pantry that feeds you all year.

How to use this calendar

This isn't a to-do list designed to make you feel behind. It's a reference — use the parts that fit your season of life and ignore the rest. A single batch of fermented carrots counts. Two jars of jam count. The goal is a pantry that helps you, not a preservation resume.

1. SCAN YOUR MONTH

Check what's in season and what's at its peak. If you're at a farmers market or have a garden glut, focus there first.

2. PICK 1–2 PROJECTS

Don't try to do everything. Pick what you'll actually use — jam you'll eat, stock you'll cook with, herbs you'll reach for.

3. CHECK THE METHOD

Each item notes its best preservation method. Canning, freezing, fermenting, dehydrating, infusing, and root cellaring are all covered throughout the months.

4. READ THE HONEST NOTES

Some things aren't worth preserving. Some are only worth it if you have a glut. We tell you which is which.

5. WRITE IN IT

This is meant to be marked up. Note what you made, how it turned out, what you'd change next year. The closing page has space.

6. REPEAT NEXT YEAR

The calendar is evergreen — same seasons, same rhythms. Each year you'll know a little more, and the notes from last year become your own reference.

A NOTE ON REGIONS

This calendar is written for temperate Northern Hemisphere seasons — roughly zones 5–8. If you're in Florida, Texas, Southern California, or the Southern Hemisphere, your seasons will shift. Use this as a rhythm, not a schedule. Local farmers market vendors will tell you more than any calendar can.

January & February — The Quiet Months

JANUARY

In season

- Citrus (oranges, grapefruit, lemons, tangerines)
- Root vegetables (beets, carrots, parsnips, turnips)
- Winter squash (still holding from fall)
- Cabbage, kale, brussels sprouts
- Leeks

Do now

Make marmalade while citrus is cheap and abundant. Start a batch of preserved lemons — they take a month and reward you all year. Ferment sauerkraut or kimchi from winter cabbage.

How to make marmalade

Ratio: *1 lb citrus + 2 lb sugar + 4 cups water. Slice fruit thinly (peel and all), soak overnight in water. Next day, simmer 1–2 hours until peel is tender. Add sugar, boil hard until a dab wrinkles on a cold plate (about 220°F if you have a thermometer). Jar and refrigerate for quick use, or water-bath can for the cupboard. Any citrus works — oranges are classic. Makes about 4–5 half-pint jars.*

MARMALADE PRESERVED LEMONS SAUERKRAUT

Honest note

Marmalade is work. It's worth doing once to understand it, but if you hate the process, good marmalade is cheap to buy. Preserved lemons, on the other hand, are expensive and dead simple — do those first.

How to make preserved lemons

Quarter 4–5 lemons almost all the way through — keep them attached at the base. Pack kosher salt into the cuts (about 1 tablespoon per lemon). Pack tightly into a clean jar, pressing down hard. Top with fresh lemon juice to cover. Seal and leave at room temperature for 3–4 weeks, shaking gently every few days. Then refrigerate — they keep for 6+ months. Chop the rind into salads, pasta, roasted vegetables, or grain bowls for bright salty depth. That's it — just lemons, salt, juice, and time.

FEBRUARY

In season

- Citrus continues (blood oranges peak)
- Root vegetables continue
- Forced rhubarb (in some regions)
- Stored apples and pears
- Winter greens

Do now

Infuse vinegars with citrus peels and herbs. Dehydrate citrus slices for garnishes and tea blends. Inventory your pantry — eat what's oldest before spring abundance arrives. Order seeds if you garden.

CITRUS VINEGAR DRIED CITRUS

Honest note

Dried citrus slices look beautiful but their actual kitchen utility is limited — they're mostly for tea and decoration. Make a small batch. Don't fill your dehydrator.

March & April — The Turn

MARCH

In season

- Spring onions, green garlic, scallions
- Asparagus (late March in warmer zones)
- Spinach, arugula, tender greens
- Rhubarb
- Last of the stored roots and apples

Do now

Pickle spring onions and scallions — they're gone in weeks and pickled onions are gold. Make rhubarb compote and freeze it. Infuse vinegar with the first herbs. Sauté mushrooms and freeze them in butter — an instant flavor base for winter cooking.

PICKLED ONIONS · RHUBARB COMPOTE · MUSHROOMS IN BUTTER

APRIL

In season

- Asparagus (peak)
- Peas, green beans
- Radishes
- Tender herbs (parsley, chives, chervil, dill)
- Spinach (peak season)

Do now

Blanch and freeze peas and green beans while they're sweet. Pickle asparagus spears — they hold their texture better than most vegetables. Dry herbs by hanging small bundles. Blanch and freeze spinach in portioned pucks for soups and pasta.

PEAS & GREEN BEANS · PICKLED ASPARAGUS · DRIED HERBS

Honest note

Frozen peas are one of the few vegetables where commercial frozen is genuinely as good as home-preserved. Only do this if you have garden peas you can't eat fresh. Otherwise, buy frozen peas and save your energy for things that matter more.

May & June — Abundance Begins

MAY

In season

- Strawberries (peak)
- Asparagus (end of season)
- Artichokes
- Spring greens, lettuces
- Radishes, turnips
- Herbs in full force

Do now

Make strawberry jam — this is the one everyone actually eats. Freeze whole strawberries on trays (then bag) for smoothies and baking. Make herb salts and herb butters and freeze them. Start a batch of herbal vinegar.

How to make herb salt

Blend 1 cup coarse sea salt with a big handful of fresh herbs (rosemary, sage, thyme, or any combo). Pulse in a food processor until the salt is green and fragrant — about 10–15 pulses. Spread on a baking sheet and let dry overnight, or dry in a 200°F oven for 15–20 minutes. Store in a jar. Use on roasted vegetables, meat, eggs, or anything that benefits from herb flavor without the fuss of fresh herbs. Keeps indefinitely.

STRAWBERRY JAM FROZEN STRAWBERRIES HERB SALT

JUNE

In season

- Cherries
- Blueberries, raspberries, blackberries begin
- Zucchini and summer squash
- Cucumbers
- Green beans
- Garlic scapes
- First new potatoes

Do now

Pickle cucumbers — quick refrigerator pickles if you're intimidated by canning, water-bath if you're ready. Pit and freeze cherries for winter baking. Ferment garlic scapes — they're milder than garlic cloves and incredible. Make berry shrub (drinking vinegar).

How to make berry shrub

A shrub is a sweet-tart drinking vinegar — mix a splash with sparkling water or use in cocktails. Mash 1 cup berries with 1 cup sugar, cover, and leave in the fridge 1–2 days. Strain out the solids, stir in 1 cup apple cider vinegar. Bottle and refrigerate. Keeps 6+ months. Try strawberry-basil, blueberry-thyme, or raspberry-mint.

DILL PICKLES GARLIC SCAPES FROZEN CHERRIES BERRY SHRUB

Honest note

Canning pickles is a gateway project. If the idea of canning intimidates you, start with refrigerator pickles — they take 15 minutes, live in the fridge for months, and teach you the fundamentals. Water-bath canning can wait.

July & August — Peak Season

JULY

In season

— Tomatoes (all types)

— Corn

— Peaches, nectarines, plums

— All berries (peak)

— Eggplant, peppers (sweet and hot)

— Green beans (glut)

— Cucumbers (glut)

Do now

This is the month. Can whole tomatoes, make salsa, roast and freeze tomato sauce. Freeze corn (blanch first). Make peach jam and plum chutney. Dry hot peppers for year-round use. Dehydrate tomatoes for "sun-dried" intensity. Ferment hot sauce.

TOMATOES & SALSA · CORN & SAUCE · HOT SAUCE · DRIED PEPPERS

AUGUST

In season

— Tomatoes continue (peak and beginning to split)

— Melons

— Figs (short window)

— Sweet corn continues

— All peppers (sweet bells, poblanos, jalapeños, habaneros)

— Eggplant

— Early apples begin

Do now

Make and can tomato passata (plain purée) — the most versatile tomato product you'll use all year. Dry figs or preserve them in honey. Roast and freeze peppers for winter cooking. Make apple butter from early apples.

PASSATA & APPLE BUTTER · DRIED FIGS · ROASTED PEPPERS · HONEY-PRESERVED FIGS

Honest note

August is overwhelming. You cannot preserve everything. Prioritize tomatoes — they're the one thing where home-preserved is genuinely and universally better than store-bought. A jar of your own August tomatoes in February will make you happier than any other thing in this calendar.

September & October — The Harvest

SEPTEMBER

In season

- Apples (peak)
- Pears
- Grapes
- Winter squash, pumpkins
- Late tomatoes
- Last peppers and eggplant
- Late sweet corn

Do now

Make applesauce and apple butter while apples are cheap by the bushel. Dry apple rings for winter snacks. Can pear halves in light syrup. Roast and freeze winter squash in cubes — it reheats beautifully. Ferment hot sauce from the last peppers. Make grape jelly or juice.

APPLESAUCE & APPLE BUTTER · DRIED APPLES · WINTER SQUASH · HOT SAUCE

Honest note

Apple butter is easier than it sounds — peeled apples, cider, sugar, spices, and a long slow cook. It fills your kitchen with the best smell and makes an excellent gift. One bushel of apples makes enough applesauce and butter to last until spring.

OCTOBER

In season

- Apples (storage varieties shine)
- Winter squash (peak)
- Pumpkins
- Cranberries
- Brussels sprouts, kale (frost-sweetened)
- Root vegetables (carrots, parsnips, beets, turnips)
- Walnuts, hazelnuts

Do now

Cure winter squash for storage — 10 days in a warm dry spot, then into the cool pantry where they'll keep for months. Make cranberry sauce and freeze it. Ferment sauerkraut from fall cabbage. Harvest root vegetables before the ground freezes — or mulch them deep and dig through winter. Roast pumpkin seeds.

CURED SQUASH · CRANBERRY SAUCE · SAUERKRAUT · ROOT VEGETABLES

How to cure winter squash

Curing isn't complicated. Leave squash in a warm (75–85°F), dry spot for 7–10 days — a sunny porch, a warm corner of the kitchen, or near the wood stove. The skin hardens and small scratches heal over. After curing, store at 50–55°F in a cool pantry or basement. Cured butternut and acorn squash keep 3–6 months. Don't refrigerate uncured squash — the cold damages them.

November & December — The Quiet Return

NOVEMBER

In season

- Stored apples and pears
- Root vegetables (in storage)
- Winter squash (cured)
- Brussels sprouts, kale (still holding)
- Cranberries (last of fresh)
- Leeks

Do now

Make stock from turkey bones and freeze it flat in bags — takes no freezer space and is ready all winter. Dehydrate mushrooms for soups and stews. Make apple cider vinegar from peels and cores. Inventory your pantry and eat what's oldest. Order seeds for next year while catalogs are fresh.

TURKEY STOCK · DRIED MUSHROOMS · APPLE CIDER VINEGAR

DECEMBER

In season

- Citrus returns (oranges, grapefruit, tangerines)
- Stored apples, root vegetables, winter squash continue
- Brussels sprouts, kale (sweetest after frost)
- Pomegranates

Do now

Make candied citrus peel — cheap, impressive, and great for holiday baking. Infuse vodka or brandy with vanilla, citrus, or spices for homemade extracts and gifts. Ferment cranberries for holiday relish. Check on your stored squash and root vegetables — remove anything that's softening. Start a batch of preserved lemons for spring.

CANDIED CITRUS · INFUSED SPIRITS · PRESERVED LEMONS

Honest note

December is not the month for big preservation projects. It's the month for using what you preserved all year. Open the applesauce. Thaw the stock. Crack into the pickles. The goal of this whole calendar was a pantry that feeds you in winter — here you are. If you preserved nothing at all this year, December citrus is your low-stakes starting point. Preserved lemons take 10 minutes and reward you in January.

The rhythm of a year

Preserving isn't about doing everything. It's about doing the right things at the right time. A few jars of tomatoes in August. A batch of pickles in July. Apple butter in October. Over time, the pantry fills itself — not through ambition, but through rhythm.

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YOUR NOTES